Screenplay assignment for the Department of Media Arts

For this second-year assignment, students are asked to write a radio piece of five minutes in length. The script needs to be in standard screenplay format as taught on the course and contain three characters and three locations across three scenes.

MARKER'S COMMENTS

Really smart storytelling using the music and bar sounds to create a powerful narrative with a strong sense of ambience, good characters and with excellent twists and revelations- with the use of recorded sound to drive the story on Johnny's playback of Ada's confession. The exposition is well concealed, and the sense of time and place is really powerful. the key to ADA's name through musical notes is a clever touch that could work well on radio.

SCENE 1. INT: THE HIDEAWAY BAR, NYC. 17:00

FX: LIGHT CLANGING AND CLINKING, WATER RUNNING, A FAR OFF RADIO PLAYING CAROLS

JOHNNY: (PRESSES PLAY ON A TAPE RECORDER. BEAUTIFUL PIANO PLAYS, WITH MUFFLED CHATTER AND LAUGHTER.)

SAWYER: Johnny! Jeez, don't freak me out like that. Thought the ghost of Christmas Pete had come to haunt me.

JOHNNY: Y'know he used to record every single one of his sets on this thing?

SAWYER: Uh-huh, would listen back for mistakes. Freakin' perfectionist.

JOHNNY: Used to try and get me to do it too.

SAWYER: Shoulda listened, you could use some sharpening up Kid!

JOHNNY: Thought I'd keep up the tradition for him now.

SAWYER: (PAUSE.) Funny thing, when people die. Those left behind find importance in every little thing… You know, I can't get this one conversation with Pete out of my head. It was a month ago, we stayed late drinking and he told me he'd had an affair. Said he had to end it cuz the girl was gettin' too attached. Intense, I think he said.

JOHNNY: What? Why wouldn't he tell me that?

SAWYER: He knew how much you looked up to him, Johnny. Anyway, probably just some weird stage of grief, but it keeps replaying in my mind. (PAUSE.) You really think he killed himself?

JOHNNY: Pete? He cared so much. Down to every note. (PAUSE.) No, I don't. (STOPS TAPE.)

FX: DOOR OPENING – LOUD STREET NOISES – AND SHUTTING. SHUFFLING FOOTSTEPS.

ADA: You're both here already. Good. Tonight has to go smoothly boys. Have you looked at the set list Johnny?

JOHNNY: About that, I thought we could add a tribute to Pete - one of his favourites.

ADA: What a wonderful idea. Please, don't think me heartless, but it's Christmas eve, y'know? Boss will kill me if we don't play carols all night. If we have time at the end...

SAWYER: Ada, come on-

ADA: Have you finished setting up the bar, Sawyer? Back to it boys, tonight has to go smoothly.

SCENE 2. INT: THE HIDEAWAY BAR, NYC. 22:00

FX: BAR NOISES – CHATTING, GLASS CLINKING, ICE TINKLING, DRUNKEN LAUGHTER

JOHNNY: (PLAYING *CAROL OF THE BELLS* ON PIANO, BUT STARTING AND STOPPING.)

ADA: Johnny, people are complaining. What's the problem?

JOHNNY: The piano, it doesn't sound right. Some of the notes are off.

ADA: Strange, it wasn't like Petey to make a mistake.

JOHNNY: What do you mean?

ADA: Oh, well, he stayed back to tune it.

JOHNNY: When? That night?

ADA: I suppose it must have been.

JOHNNY: He didn't tell me it needed retuning-

ADA: The show must go on, you have to finish the set.

JOHNNY: Out of tune?

ADA: Have you seen your audience? This isn't the Ritz, Johnny. And please, play a cheery one, eh? You're gonna depress Santa Claus before the big day.

SCENE 3. INT: THE HIDEAWAY BAR, NYC. 02:00

FX: SWEEPING UP GLASS.

JOHNNY: (PLAYING *RAIN DROP* BY CHOPIN QUIETLY AT THE PIANO)

ADA: All done. Good job tonight, Johnny. Petey would've been proud. You going home?

JOHNNY: I think I'll stay, retune.

ADA: Okey dokey. I'll leave you keys to lock up then. (KEYS JANGLE.)

JOHNNY: Wait, Ada? (PAUSE.) Why didn't you come to Pete's funeral? (PLAYS LOUDER.)

ADA: I told you, I wish I could have. I had a family emerg-

JOHNNY: Family emergency – right. I remember now.

ADA: I heard you did a beautiful speech- why are you playing that?

JOHNNY: You were right earlier. Pete did not make mistakes. Ever. And if he did, he fixed them.

ADA: The tuning? He was out of sorts that night Johnny, otherwise he wouldn't have… do you have to play that?

JOHNNY: Sawyer told me about his affair, and I remembered the way you used to watch him play. At the time I thought you just admired him, like we all did. But you didn't come to his funeral, Ada. And now you can't bear to listen to his favourite song. (SONG REACHES CLIMAX.)

ADA: (RAISED VOICE.) It's called grief, Johnny.

JOHNNY: Do you know which strings are out of tune, Ada? Can you guess which *three* notes Pete left out of tune that night? (PLAYS EACH NOTE AS HE SAYS IT.) The A, D, and A sharp.

ADA: Just stop.

JOHNNY: He never made mistakes, ADA.

ADA: (LONG PAUSE.) It's simple really. I loved him. He was going to leave me, and now he can't.

JOHNNY: So you killed him? He's left us all now, Ada.

ADA: They'll never believe you, Johnny. Merry Christmas.

FX: DOOR OPENS AND SLAMS HARD.

JOHNNY: (REWINDS TAPE RECORDER AND PRESSES PLAY.)

TAPE: -simple really. I loved him. He was going to leave me, and now he can't. So you killed him? He's left us all now, Ada. They'll never believe you, Johnny. Merry Christmas. (CLICK.)